**Raymond Blanc**, Chef Patron of Le Manoir aux Quat' Saisons, Oxfordshire (UK), says, "This soup offers a multitude of flavors which can vary with the seasons."

# vegetable and chervil soup

**SERVES** 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 10–12 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

1 tbsp unsalted butter
1 onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, finely chopped
2 large carrots, finely sliced
3 celery ribs, sliced into ¼in (½cm) pieces
2 medium leeks, sliced into ¾in (1cm) chunks
salt and freshly ground white pepper
1 large zucchini, halved lengthwise and cut into ¼in (½cm) slices
2 ripe tomatoes, quartered and coarsely chopped
1 tbsp unsalted butter or sour cream
1 tbsp chervil, finely chopped
crème fraîche, to serve (optional)

1 Melt the butter in a pan and cook the onion, garlic, carrots, celery, and leeks for 5 minutes (do not allow them to color). Season with salt and freshly ground white pepper.

2 Add 1 quart (1 liter) boiling water, the zucchini, and tomatoes (using boiling water will reduce the cooking time and also keep the lively colors). Fast boil for another 5 minutes only—it is vital that you do not spoil the fresh, clean flavors of your vegetables by overcooking.

3 Whisk in the butter or sour cream (or both) and add the chervil. Taste and correct the seasoning if required, and blend the soup if you would like a finer texture. Pour into a large tureen and serve to your guests. A spoon of crème fraîche would always be welcome.